

EXPRESS PHOTO BY PARTHA PAUL

LAL'S LAST GAMBIT

Sidelined and frustrated, Bhajan Lal breaks away from the Congress to form a new party signalling the emergence of a potent third front in the state

■ By Ramesh Vinayak

Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda has a rather curious hobby—organising political rallies. In 32 months in power, he has organised 84 such shows across the state but none has stirred the politics of the Jatland as visibly as the *Jan Hit* (people's welfare) rally on December 2 by the dissident Congress stalwart Bhajan Lal and his son, MP Kuldeep Bishnoi. The buzz is not just because of the massive show of strength at the carefully chosen venue of Rohtak—the home turf of their arch rival Hooda and also the political capital of the state—but also because they have launched a separate political party christened as Haryana Janhit Congress (BJ).

The audacious gambit by the rebellious father-son duo has made the Congress jittery. Not only does the formation of the new outfit mark the first major revolt in the Congress by a powerful state satrap since it came to power at the Centre in 2004, it signals the emergence of a third front in Haryana. So far, the Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) of Om Prakash Chautala, has been the only challenger to the Congress in the state's bipolar political arena. While an ageing and ailing Bhajan Lal—a three-time chief minister who resigned as the state Congress chief 11 months ago—has cast himself as figure-head of the breakaway entity, 40-year-old Bishnoi, a firebrand Congress MP from Bhiwani, has formally taken over the mantle of the Lal legacy by becoming the party president. Quite appropriately, the party has chosen the rising sun as its symbol—an allusion to the ascent of the son of the only surviving Lal of the three famous Lals of Haryana, the others being Devi Lal and Bansi Lal.

Politically, the split in the Haryana Congress poses no immediate threat to Hooda who is firmly in the saddle. Out of the 67-MLA-strong Congress legislature party in the house of 90, only three MLAs have openly sided with Lal. He had fallen out with the party high command after his claim to chief ministership was ignored despite



MACE OF REVOLT:
Bishnoi (left) and Lal take the fight to the next stage

“Our party will be a potent alternative to Hooda and Chautala in Haryana.”

KULDEEP BISHNOI, PRESIDENT, HARYANA JANHIT CONGRESS (BJ)